and austerities (the path of devotion); and the intellectual, with a serious study of philosophy and theology (the path of knowledge). Most Hindus never get beyond the first stage; their Hinduism is a religion of temple visits, fasts to propitiate favourite gods, the observance of specific festivals according to the tradition in their geographic regions. But even for the others, who demand more from (and look for more in) their faith, their quest for the truth, their enquiry into the mysteries of Creation, would not end with a blinding flash of realisation from the pages of a sacred book. After all, unlike the Bible, the Dialogues of the Buddha, and the Quran, all the unchallengeable principal texts of their religions, even the *Vedas* are merely the first in a substantial corpus of scriptural works.

It is also true that in a religion as vast, capacious and evolving as Hinduism, there is much in the religious texts that contradict themselves, and each scholar can find scriptural justification for a point of view diametrically opposed to that of another scholar, also with his own scriptural justification. Take, for example, the place of women in Hindu society, which has undoubtedly undergone much transformation, for better and for worse. The epics, the *Manusmriti* and the dicta of Yajnavalkya, putative author of the *Yajnavalkya-smriti*, all contain much material that is bloodcurdlingly misogynist in relegating women to a place of inferiority in relation to men. Bhishma in the Anushasana Parva of the *Mahabharata* declares: 'Women have one eternal duty in this world: dependence upon and obedient service to their husbands.' And yet this is the faith that regarded wives as *ardhangini*, half of the whole, and *sahadharmini*, the partner of the man in the fulfilment of *dharma*. The sage Sayana, in his commentary on the *Rig Veda*, wrote: 'The wife and the husband, being the equal halves of one substance, are equal in every respect; both should join and take equal part in all work, religious and secular.' A warrior queen like Kaikeyi strode on to the battlefield alongside her husband. Swami Vivekananda pointed out with pride that some of the most exalted *rishi*s of the Hindu faith, the most learned and respected authorities on the scriptures, are women. (Twenty-one of the original *rishika*s to whom the *Vedas* were revealed were women: the names of Gargi and Maitreyi today adorn colleges in Delhi University;